

Nothing New Under the Sun

AI, Sense Perception, and the God Who Grounds All Knowing

The Kiln Ministries / Great Physician Application

Sources: Bavinck, Christian Worldview; Bavinck, Philosophy of Revelation; Holy Scripture

Preface

The anxiety about artificial intelligence is real, widespread, and — in its better forms — theologically serious. This essay offers a serious answer, drawn not from the latest headlines but from a Dutch Reformed theologian who died in 1921 and who saw the crisis coming more clearly than most of his contemporaries.

Herman Bavinck did not write about artificial intelligence. He wrote about something more fundamental: the question of where human knowledge comes from, what it can reach, and what lies permanently beyond its grasp. His answer — worked out across Christian Worldview and the ten Stone Lectures of Philosophy of Revelation — provides a framework that locates AI precisely on the map of human knowing, neither dismissing its genuine power nor mistaking it for something it can never be.

The thesis is simple: AI is the most powerful inductive engine ever built — the apex of what sense perception, organized and scaled beyond human individual capacity, can achieve. Because Bavinck shows us that all sense perception is grounded in God, we can receive AI's genuine achievements with gratitude while remaining clear-eyed about what no amount of inductive power can ever supply.

I. The Anxiety and the Ancient Answer

Artificial intelligence has produced a cultural anxiety that cuts across every ideological and religious boundary. Technologists worry about alignment. Parents worry about their children. Educators worry about integrity. Theologians worry about the soul. These worries are not foolish. The technology is genuinely powerful, genuinely novel in its form, and

genuinely difficult to evaluate with the tools most people have available.

But the sense that nothing like this has ever happened before — that we stand at a uniquely unprecedented threshold — is worth interrogating. And the place to interrogate it is Ecclesiastes.

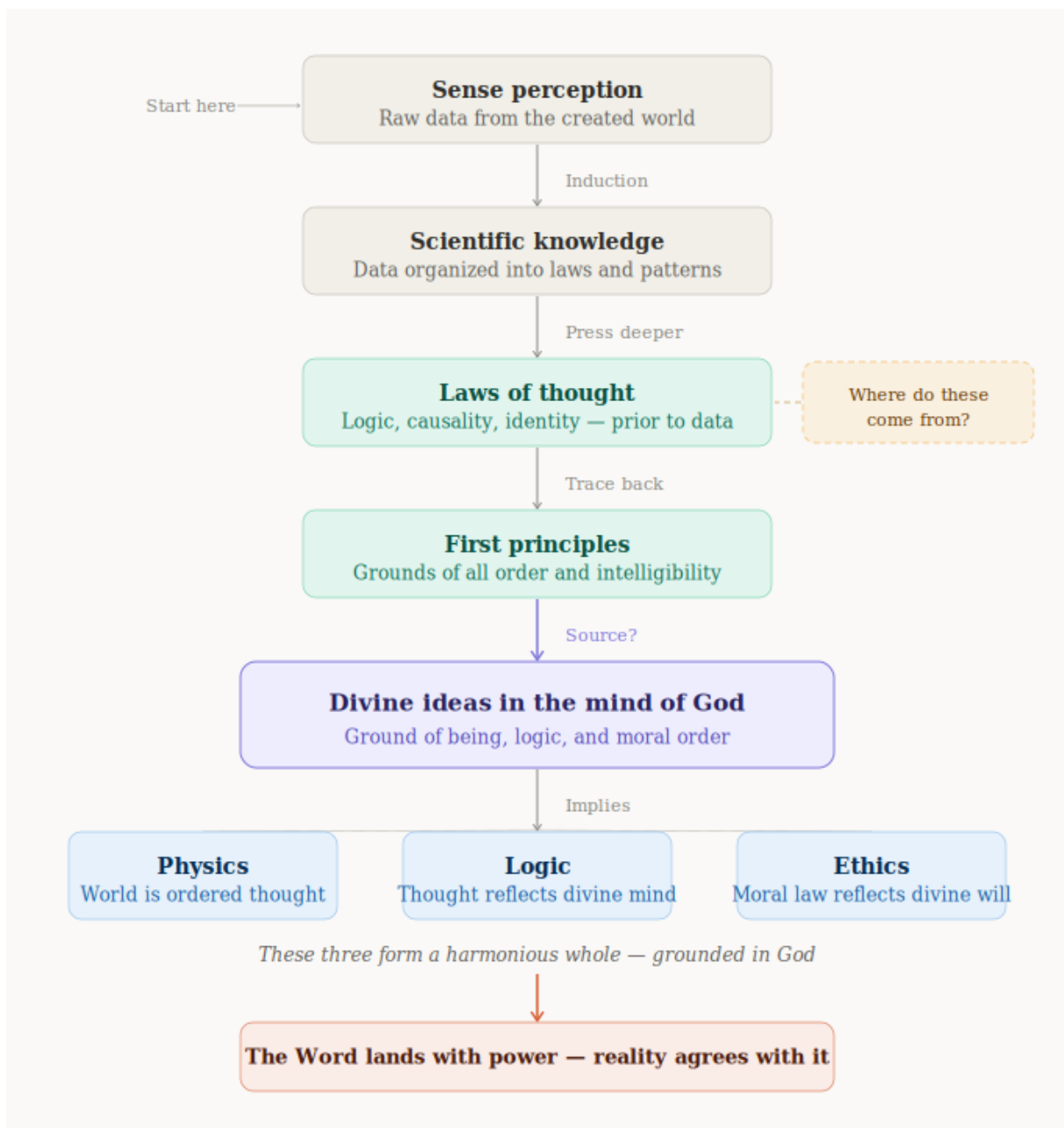
'What has been is what will be, and what has been done is what will be done, and there is nothing new under the sun.' (Ecclesiastes 1:9)

The Preacher is saying something precise: the structure of human experience, the kinds of challenges that arise when creatures of finite wisdom build powerful things in a fallen world — these do not change with the technology. The printing press produced anxiety about dangerous ideas. Newtonian mechanics produced anxiety about a clockwork universe. Darwin produced anxiety about human dignity. The atom bomb produced anxiety about annihilation. In each case, the theological question underneath was the same: What is the human being, and what does he need that no tool can give him?

Bavinck was writing at one of those waves — the cresting of scientific naturalism. His response was not defensive. He walked straight into the epistemological argument and showed, from within it, where the argument leads — and where it cannot go.

II. The Ascent: From Sense Perception to First Principles

Bavinck's argument in *Christian Worldview* begins exactly where the skeptic begins: with sense perception and the science it makes possible. He does not start with the Bible and deduce downward. He starts on the ground floor of empirical experience and asks what must be true for knowledge to be possible at all.



Bavinck's epistemological ascent — from sense perception to the divine ideas that ground all knowing

You begin with sense data. Science takes this raw data and organizes it through rigorous method into laws and patterns. This is genuine achievement. But press a level deeper and a problem appears. To organize the data into laws, you must already be using something not derived from the data: the laws of thought. Logic. Causality. The assumption that the same causes produce the same effects. The confidence that your reasoning faculty corresponds to what is actually true.

Where do these come from? You cannot derive them from sense data, because you must already be using them to evaluate any sense data. You cannot justify them by argument, because every argument already assumes them. And they work — in a way that has no explanation within the purely empirical framework. Why does the structure of the mind correspond to the structure of the world? Why does mathematics, developed in pure abstraction, describe physical reality with uncanny precision?

Follow that thread back to its source and you arrive at the first principles — and behind them, the divine ideas: the eternal archetypes in the mind of God in whom all things were created. The world is knowable because it was first thought. The laws of logic are reliable because they reflect the structure of the divine mind. The uniformity of nature is grounded in the faithfulness of the Creator.

Bavinck's conclusion: physics, logic, and ethics are not three separate domains that happen to coexist. They are three expressions of a single divine wisdom. This is not a retreat from reason — it is reason followed honestly all the way to its own ground.

III. AI Is Exactly What You Would Expect

Artificial intelligence is, in the most precise possible sense, the apex of the bottom of Bavinck's diagram. It is sense perception organized, scaled, and automated to a degree unimaginable a generation ago. A large language model ingests incomprehensible quantities of human-produced text and finds patterns within it at a depth and scale no human mind could achieve. It is extraordinarily powerful.

And it cannot, by its own operations, take a single step up Bavinck's diagram. It cannot ask where the laws of logic come from. It cannot reach the first principles that ground its own processing. It cannot arrive at the divine ideas that make sense perception possible in the first place. It is constitutionally a creature of the inductive order — astonishingly capable within that order, and entirely unable to transcend it.

This is not a criticism of AI. It is a description. And the description is clarifying, because it tells you exactly what AI can do and exactly where it stops.

The anxiety about AI is, at its root, a theological anxiety — the uneasy sense that we have built something of enormous power without first principles adequate to govern it. That anxiety will not be resolved by better safety guidelines alone. It will only be resolved by the move Bavinck makes: following the argument all the way up to the ground on which sense

perception stands. The person who has made that move can look at AI and say: yes, of course. This is what a civilization that has become very good at sense perception produces when it scales that capacity to its limit. Genuinely powerful. Genuinely limited. I know both, because I know where sense perception stands in relation to the God who grounds it.

IV. What Sense Perception Cannot Give You

The person in spiritual distress does not primarily need more information. He does not need a more efficient pattern-matching engine applied to his situation. He needs what Bavinck identifies as the content of genuine religion: strength, life, a personal power that can pardon sin, receive him into favor, and cause him to triumph joyfully over a world of sin and death.

Sense perception cannot supply any of this. AI cannot supply it — not because it is too weak, but because these things do not live at the level of the inductive order at all. They live at the level Bavinck calls revelation: the self-disclosure of the God who grounds all knowing, addressed to the creature who needs not better data but a restored relationship with the One who made him.

The Word of God is not one data point among many. It is the self-attestation of the One in whom all data has its coherence. When it is spoken to a person in distress, it lands as the most fundamental statement of how reality actually is — because the God who spoke it is the same God whose thought underlies the logic, the physics, and the moral order of the world that person inhabits. The Word lands with power because reality agrees with it. The two were made by the same mind.

V. Gratitude, Proportion, and the Gospel

What is the right posture toward AI for the Christian? Not fear — because the God who grounds all sense perception is not threatened by the apex of its development. There is nothing new under the sun — not as a counsel of despair but as a statement of sovereign calm.

Not uncritical enthusiasm — because the person who mistakes the bottom of the diagram for everything has confused the instrument with the ground. The one who thinks AI can give him what only God can give him is in the same position as every generation that has made a similar mistake with a different tool.

The right posture is clear-eyed gratitude. Receive the genuine achievements of sense perception — including AI — as gifts of the Creator's common grace, products of the created order's God-given intelligibility. Use them freely, wisely, and with full awareness of what they are.

And know that they point, every one of them, toward something they cannot supply. The laws of logic point toward the divine mind. The uniformity of nature points toward the faithfulness of the Creator. The remarkable fact that the world is knowable at all points toward the Word by whom it was made. Every genuine achievement of human knowing is, whether the knower acknowledges it or not, a testimony to the God in whom all knowing is grounded.

That God has not left us with only a diagram. He has entered the world he made. He has spoken in a way that no amount of inductive power could have predicted or produced. He has addressed the condition that no tool can reach — the guilt, the broken relationship, the darkened mind — with the one thing that can actually heal it: the gospel of his Son.

'For from him and through him and to him are all things. To him be glory forever.'

(Romans 11:36)

AI is a powerful instrument. The gospel is the destination. And the Christian who keeps those two things in their proper places will be neither afraid of the one nor confused about where to find the other.